

STOP TITHING!

Blue denotes PPT slide

Brown denotes instructions to technician

TEXT: Malachi 3:1-12 (CEV) *“I, the LORD All-Powerful, will send my messenger to prepare the way for me. Then suddenly the Lord you are looking for will appear in his temple. The messenger you desire is coming with my promise, and he is on his way. A Day of Change ² On the day the Lord comes, he will be like a furnace that purifies silver or like strong soap in a washbasin. No one will be able to stand up to him. ³ The LORD will purify the descendants of Levi, as though they were gold or silver. Then they will bring the proper offerings to the LORD, ⁴ and the offerings of the people of Judah and Jerusalem will please him, just as they did in the past. Don’t Cheat God ⁵ The LORD All-Powerful said: I’m now on my way to*

judge you. And I will quickly condemn all who practice witchcraft or cheat in marriage or tell lies in court or rob workers of their pay or mistreat widows and orphans or steal the property of foreigners or refuse to respect me. ⁶ Descendants of Jacob, I am the LORD All-Powerful, and I never change. That's why you haven't been wiped out, ⁷ even though you have ignored and disobeyed my laws ever since the time of your ancestors. But if you return to me, I will return to you. And yet you ask, "How can we return?" ⁸ You people are robbing me, your God. And, here you are, asking, "How are we robbing you?" You are robbing me of the offerings and of the ten percent that belongs to me. ⁹ That's why your whole nation is under a curse. ¹⁰ I am the LORD All-Powerful, and I challenge you to put me to the test. Bring the entire ten percent into the storehouse, so there will be food in my house. Then I will open the windows of heaven and flood you with

blessing after blessing. ¹¹ I will also stop locust from destroying your crops and keeping your vineyards from producing. ¹² Everyone of every nation will talk about how I have blessed you and about your wonderful land. I, the LORD All-Powerful, have spoken!”

INTOR: Most people simply don't understand tithing. To many Christians it seems like just another bill, in the long list of monthly expenses.

Giving is supposed to be an act of worship that draws us closer to the heart of God. Giving should be to the Christian what intimacy is to a married couple.

When there is constant intimacy in a marriage the couple is brought together in a way that nothing else can reproduce.

When there is consistent intimacy in a marriage the souls of the individuals are merged. There is a term called “*Alienation of affection,*” and in most states, until recently this has been a prosecutable offense. This law can be enacted when someone has an affair with a married person. This law allows for the “*other woman/man*” can be prosecuted for “*Alienation of affection.*”

When intimacy is lost from a marriage there is a danger that one or both parties in the marriage will cheat. This is why we are instructed in the Word of God to not withhold intimacy from our marriage partner for extended periods of time, “***Lest we be tempted.***”

Giving builds a trust between God and His child that cannot be reproduced by any other means. When we fail to live up to our

financial responsibilities toward God we are cheating on Him!

Trust produces intimacy. Intimacy takes us to a place in God that cannot be produced in any other way. If this is true, then why is it that the concept of tithing, giving the first ten percent of one's income, is so difficult for Christians to start and maintain?

Christians debate questions like: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- **Is tithing still required?** (The only good thing Jesus ever said about the Pharisees is that they paid tithe)
- **Isn't tithing an Old Testament law?** (Tithing predates the law of Moses when Abraham paid tithe to Melchizedec)
- **Didn't Christ abolish the law with His death and resurrection?** (Christ's death fulfilled the sacrificial part of the law, it did not abolish the commandments)

- Should I tithe off the gross or net of my income? (Are we expecting a net blessing or a gross blessing?)
- Does God really expect me to tithe if I'm struggling in my personal finances? (To cease being generous with God when one is struggling would be to complicate the situation)

These questions all have the same recurring theme, “*What’s the least I can give and still receive God’s blessings.*” Let me ask all the married people in the house today, how many of you would be excited about a physical relationship with a spouse that has the attitude of duty rather than excitement and expectation?

When you debate these questions, you totally miss the point. Biblical generosity is not about seeing how little one can give; it is about a spirit of generosity. How can we feel good about being anything less than

generous when we are serving a God who
*“So loved the world that He gave His only
begotten Son?”*

Randy Alcorn said, *“Giving affirms Christ’s
lordship. It dethrones me and exalts Him.”*
**(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL
NEXT SLIDE)**

Tithers write checks like, \$115.26. People
who stop tithing and step into a spirit of
generosity write checks like \$200.00!

When we write a check for \$115.26 our
attitude becomes, *“Here’s my ten percent,
hopefully that will cover the upkeep in
Heaven until my next paycheck. Now bless
me.”*

God doesn’t need our money! He is building
a city where the cheapest building material
is gold! He is making streets out of the stuff!
He is looking for proof that He is first in our

lives. He wants me to step into such an intimate relationship with Him that I will stop tithing and begin a journey of generosity.

A person who is tied to tithing writes checks for \$115.26 because they believe they are the owner! They have not stepped into the belief that everything belongs to God. [Psalm 24:1 \(KJV\)](#) ***“The earth is the LORD's, and the fulness thereof; the world, and they that dwell therein.”***

God wants us to stop tithing and start trusting Him completely. The more we trust Him with our finances, the more He can use us to reveal His glory. When we stop tithing and step into a spirit of generosity we become a conduit for His miracles!

The more my faith gets tested on a financial level and I go beyond my ten percent the

more likely it is that He can reveal the miraculous through me!

People who have stopped tithing and stepped off into generosity have quit asking “*How much should I give*” and have started asking, “*How much should I keep?*”

When tithing is talked about, Malachi 3:8-10 is always in the mix but I want to look at verses 1-4. Malachi 3:1-4 (CEV) *“I, the LORD All-Powerful, will send my messenger to prepare the way for me. Then suddenly the Lord you are looking for will appear in his temple. The messenger you desire is coming with my promise, and he is on his way. A Day of Change² On the day the Lord comes, he will be like a furnace that purifies silver or like strong soap in a washbasin. No one will be able to stand up to him.³ The LORD will purify the descendants of Levi, as though they were gold or silver. Then they will bring the*

proper offerings to the LORD, ⁴ *and the offerings of the people of Judah and Jerusalem will please him, just as they did in the past.* **Don't Cheat God.” (LEAVE this SCRIPTURE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL I AM FINISHED WITH THE FOLLOWING BULLET POINTS)**

Look at this:

- The Lord will appear in His temple... Vs. 1 *“The Lord you are looking for will appear in his temple.”*
- The Lord is coming... Vs. 1 *“The messenger you desire is coming, He is on his way.”*
- The Lord is coming with a promise... Vs. 1 *“The messenger you desire is coming with my promise, and he is on his way.”*
- The Lord is bringing big changes... Vs. 1 *“The messenger you desire is coming with my promise, and he is on his way. A Day of Change.”*

- The Lord is bringing a refining fire...
Vs.2 ***“On the day the Lord comes, he will be like a furnace that purifies silver...”***
- The lord is bringing soap and water...
Vs. 2 ***“On the day the Lord comes, he will be like a furnace that purifies silver or like strong soap in a washbasin.”***
- THEN the people will bring PROPER offerings... Vs. 3 ***“Then they will bring the proper offerings to the LORD.”***
- If we don’t give a PROPER offering, we are cheating on God... Vs. 4 ***“The offerings of the people of Judah and Jerusalem will please him, just as they did in the past. Don’t Cheat God.”***
- Proper offerings please the Lord... Vs. 4 ***“The offerings of the people of Judah and Jerusalem will please him.”*** (Not offerings of \$115.26!)

CONCLUSION:

I believe today will be the day that CT Church stops tithing and embraces generosity and intimacy with God! Everything changes for most of us today!

If we take this step today, I believe we will go to spiritual heights we have never experienced before. I believe we will see victories we have never embraced before! We will see Kingdom things spring onto the screen of our lives!

I believe we have limited God by tithing and not being generous! I release over this place a spirit of generosity!

Today, God is calling us to a new level financially! I am trying to make you uncomfortable and push you to a brand new level of faith in your life! (Before I came to CT I had to get uncomfortable with where I was)

I am trying to give you a Faith Lift! God doesn't just want our first 10%, He wants our whole heart.

PLACES PREACHED:

CT Houston & Pasadena 3/2/14